16. Animals — raising, feeding, treating and using them

Oracle OS guide. **Illustrated** manuals in the library: CVM "Raising Healthy" (goats, rabbits, poultry, pigs, sheep, cattle) and "Drugs and their usage", Peace Corps and FAO (beekeeping), Langstroth, "Poultry", "Sheep, Swine, and Poultry", "Pratt's Practical Pointers", "Domestic Animals"; cheese and bread in "Seeds and grains".

Where to start

1. **Chickens**: daily eggs, meat, eat scraps and insects, excellent manure. Coop shut at night (foxes), 4–5 m² of run per bird, nest box, perch, clean water. A broody hen sits ~21 days; keep a cockerel for chicks.
2. **Rabbits**: fast breeding (gestation ~31 days, 6–8 kits), eat grass and garden scraps, lean meat. Dry shaded hutches; keep bucks apart.
3. **Goats**: milk (1–3 L/day), meat, hide; browse scrub. Strong fences; goats need company. Gestation ~150 days.
4. **Bees**: honey (sugar and antiseptic), wax (candles, waterproofing), pollination. See "Small-scale beekeeping".
5. **Pigs, sheep and cattle**: need more land and feed; sheep give wool (see "Textiles and leather"), cattle milk and traction.

Animal health — signs of illness

Isolate any animal that: stops eating, is dull, has diarrhoea, cough, nasal/eye discharge, lameness, weight loss or fever. Wash hands before and after. New animals stay in quarantine 2–3 weeks before joining the group.

- **Parasites**: rotate pastures, clean bedding, check the inner eyelid colour (pale = worm anaemia; see the FAMACHA method in the manuals).
- **Wounds**: clean, remove maggots, disinfect, protect from flies.
- **Birth**: mostly unaided; intervene only if straining >30–60 min without progress — clean, lubricated hands, pull with contractions, down and back.
- **Zoonoses** (spread to people): rabies (bites — wash 15 min), brucellosis (boil milk!), tuberculosis, salmonella (wash dirty eggs, cook meat well), mange, ringworm.

Feeding

Pasture and hay (cut and dry grass in summer for winter), garden scraps, cracked grain, acorns (pigs), dried nettles (hens). Clean water always. Salt/minerals for ruminants.

Using the products

- **Milk**: milk with clean hands and udder; **boil or pasteurise** (72 °C for 15 s or 63 °C for 30 min). Cheese: rennet (kid/calf stomach) or acid (lemon, vinegar); see "The Book of Cheese".
- **Slaughter and meat**: stun first (firm blow to the head), bleed at once, hang, skin/pluck, gut without tearing intestines, cool. Preserve: salt, smoke, dry, lard.

- **Hides and wool**: see "Textiles and leather". **Bones**: tools, needles, glue (boil). **Fat**: candles, soap ("Basic chemistry"). **Manure**: compost and, dried, fuel.

Animal traction

Donkeys, horses and oxen: well-fitted yoke/collar, trimmed hooves, rest and water every 1–2 h of work. Plough, cart, water wheel (noria), millstone.